

Just like plants on land, water-based plants need sunlight to make food and have found their own unique ways to survive. Plants such as the **flowering rush** and **water lily** are rooted at the bottom of ponds and rivers but push out long leaves to capture sunlight and tall flower stalks to be pollinated by insects. The feathery leaves of the **fanwort** and **hornwort** spread out

to let the water drift freely through without tearing them. **Water hyacinths** and **water lettuces** trap air in their leaves to help them float. While some water plants provide a habitat and food for fish and other aquatic animals, others such as **waterweed** and **parrot's feather** grow so quickly that they often take over lakes and streams, harming other plants and the animals that live there.



Umbrella grass

Tufts of leaves protect the developing flowers.

Water lettuce

Tall stems carry leaves that resemble umbrella spokes.

Tiny hairs trap air to help the plant float.

Leaves grow up to 6½ ft (2 m) long.

Brazilian waterweed

Dense leaves can be up to 1 in (3 cm) long.

Parrot's feather

Bright green feathery leaves and stem can stand up to 11¾ in (30 cm) out of the water.

Pairs of flowers form a V shape.

Water hawthorn

The **earliest plants** to grow on Earth evolved in **water**.

Clumps of eelgrass form meadows under the ocean.

Common eelgrass

American eelgrass

